

MANAGEMENT
• LEADERSHIP

THE EMPATHETIC CEO

BY MAMTA SHARMA

IS THE AGE OF THE
EXTROVERTED,
LARGER-THAN-LIFE
CEO COMING TO AN
END AS QUIETER, MORE
BALANCED LEADERS—
WHO BLEND EMPATHY,
DECISIVENESS AND
PRESENCE—SHAPE THE
FUTURE OF WORK?

WHEN GOOGLE CEO Sundar Pichai calmly fields tough questions from employees at an all-hands meeting, or when Microsoft CEO Satya Nadella calls empathy a superpower, it signals a quiet shift in corporate culture: Flamboyance is passé, modesty is motivating.

Experts and corporate observers say this cultural shift is also visible back home, where “dynamic leadership” has long been equated with charisma and visibility. N. Chandrasekaran, Chairperson of Tata Sons, has guided the Tata group through major transformations with a steady hand and a

willing ear. Leena Nair runs Chanel with a people-first approach that prizes inclusion and listening as much as bold decision-making.

“The demand is for leaders who can listen deeply as well as inspire teams. It’s less about razzle and dazzle and more about balancing visibility with depth,” says Neha Parashar, an executive and career coach. “The classic image of the charismatic, stage-commanding CEO is losing sheen; the world has become too complex for the old archetype,” she says.

Indeed, the era of a flamboyant Richard Branson or a passionate Steve Jobs looks all but over. The current tribe of corporate leaders